

Some less known facts about Rahul Singh

Favourite Actor: Christian Bale
Favourite Actress: Charlize Theron
Favourite Sport: Football and Formula 1
Favourite Sports Person: Oliver Kahn
Favourite Movie: Marvel series
Cars or Bikes: Bikes
Bike I ride today: None
Bike I want to ride one day: Ducati Scrambler
Car I drive today: Skoda Superb
Favourite food: Eton Mess
Go to person: Elder brother

means to him. One of these incidents happened around the time when Rahul and his friends were about to graduate from IIT Bombay and hence decided to go for a road trip one last time.

"We decided to do this one long road trip together before graduating as some of the friends were moving to countries outside India," recalls Rahul.

The plan which was initially for all his friends boiled down to just Rahul and another friend of his as others kept dropping out. Rahul's bike was hit by a school bus on the day of the road trip and he ended up burning his back due to the hot exhaust of the bike. Rahul got medical treatment and decided to continue with the road trip as the friend accompanying him was to leave for Germany after the trip.

"I thought I couldn't leave this opportunity and reschedule the road trip. The plan was to ride from Bombay to Bangalore, if possible, non-stop. I look back and find that to be a foolish decision now," he says.

Though they wanted to complete the ride the same day, they didn't leave early in the morning and started late.

"We started the road trip at 10am and got exhausted by the time we reached near Karnataka. My brother called me after dinner and told me to stay where we were and continue the journey in the morning. But we were high on this thing that it had to be non-stop and carried on with the ride late in the night," recalls Rahul.

This is how Rahul met with an accident that almost killed him. There was some repair work going on at a stretch of the highway and Rahul fell nearly ten metres down in a canal along with his bike.

"There was no stop sign and I ran off a cliff. I fell 30 feet into a completely dry canal. My bike and I broke a lot of things in our body. My friend pulled me out of the canal with the help of some locals and I was rushed to a nearby hospital. I was informed of a broken back bone and shattered face," he recalls about that road trip.

"We did two foolish things at that time. One we rushed into the road trip without carefully planning it and two we left for the road trip without having any medical insurance," he says.

He adds, "It was once again my elder brother who came to the rescue. He rushed over after listening to what had happened to me and took care of me and all the medical bills. I still bank on him for all the decisions of my life."

The drone view

The story behind Rahul and his friends coming together to start Ideaforge as a drone startup draws encouragement from their love for robotics. All the co-founders of Ideaforge see robotics as a game changer for humankind and see potential in the same to change the course of lives of humans.

"What I feel is, if someone is interested in physical sciences and devices to get things done, robotics is the end game for them. For me a fan is a robot, a light bulb is a robot. These are a combination of multiple things coming together to make something happen. This has always been the core area of interest to me," he says.

Rahul adds, "Interestingly, I stumbled upon the co-founders of Ideaforge in IIT Bombay and they had the same view about sciences. It is because of the alignment of the same views we managed to start Ideaforge and have gone through the most challenging of times as founders and friends."

The first thing these friends started working upon was a hovercraft in the IIT campus. Later, the hovercraft idea transcended to a quad-copter idea. The quad-copter made the co-founders realise the brilliance of the idea. They started reading more about quad-copters and were astonished to see how people from different geographies of the world were trying to work

on the same idea.

"Back in 2003 we realised that this was something that Leonardo DiVinci had sketched about long-long back. We now knew that the concept had existed, and we also got hooked to its simplicity," recalls Rahul.

He adds, "This project was one that neither relied on heavy electronics nor on heavy mechanical engineering. This required a good blend of both and was very simple in approach. Keeping things simple for making it work continues to be the best thing about it. Imagine a helicopter which needs thousands of parts to be active and then imagine quad-copters which are conveniently simple. That exact thought crossed our minds and Ideaforge was born."

The journey of Ideaforge after that has been about optimising the already simple systems further in order to make them more efficient. The team at Ideaforge is now trying to build drone solutions for every part of the world.

Back in 2007, the friends came together and established a company that's now turning every head in India, instead of going for full-time employment after IIT, due to lack of core product development jobs in the country back then. Rahul, who has done an internship at one of the biggest organisations in the country, feels that it was always product development that excited him, and continues to excite him.

"What I feel is that different industries in India need to collaborate and develop solutions for the entire world. We need to carve out a name for India in the hardware domain. If we were not there yesterday does not mean we can't be there today or tomorrow," says Rahul.

"Instead of having multiple small kingdoms fighting each other, it is good to have one large kingdom working towards one goal," he adds.

Rahul's future plans include taking Ideaforge global and transforming the company into a place where people enjoy working and create the best drone solutions possible. Who knows, Rahul and Ideaforge's co-founders might step up to disrupt the automation and robotics industry soon, just like they have done in drones' arena! **EFY**

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